February 2025

***Peer Knowledge Commons and SNS:***
https://chatgpt.com/share/67be8c35-6ca0-8002-9711-e20dbc3b283e

**- CUNY:** Historical imperative with roots in the pandemic's effect on teaching and learning, especially for CUNY students displaced or spurned by emergency distance learning
**- Reddit:** histories of topic-based discussion forums, newsprint and advice-column register, folksonomies of flair and the help center,
**- Discord:** mapping asynchronous SMS communication in terms of digital orality: a legitimate and widespread everyday writing practice for CUNY students

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## Peer Support Networks as Literacy Work

As institutions grapple with the need for sustainable practices and equitable access to educational resources, strategic planning invites a reevaluation of where college student read, write, and learn in our digital era (Yang et al., 2021). I consider this need by first adopting the concept of "literacy work" via LaFrance's adoption of the term, itself adopted from the anthropological tradition of institutional ethnography, to understand how students enter into composition with one another on Reddit or Discord. I orient this research along the lines of boyd's (2017) ethnographic studies of youth culture and networked publics to provide "thick descriptions" of how young paper engage these digital spaces, and to shed light on the digital fluency and networked sociability of past, present, and future generations of college students. Just as teens in boyd's study leveraged social networks for "gossiping, flirting, joking around, sharing information, and simply hanging out" (p. 84), today's college students demonstrate an impressive range of rhetorical moves, organizing tactics, and reflective practices in these spaces. In other words, social and academic learning in these spaces exceeds that of merely gaming the system. These literacies are *strategic* and well-coordinated social projects that demonstrate many of the skills boyd identifies in her ethnography of social networking practices among youth populations at onset of the Web 2.0., which are persistence, searchability, replicability, and scalability.

- Current research reveals that established university models often fail to recognize the value of informal learning environments that students cultivate online. These insights

underscore how interactions on platforms like Reddit and Discord reflect a complex interplay of power, identity, and knowledge as students navigate their roles within these digital communities (Chang et al., 2021).

- The implications of surveillance capitalism in educational contexts raise critical questions about the ethics of digital engagement in unofficially outsource educational settings, highlighting how students simultaneously act as consumers of information and contributors to broader discourses that challenge traditional educational hierarchies (Mintz, 2021).

## Revisiting the Peer Knowledge Commons

The presence of commoning practices among student communities reflects what Hauser (1999) describes as “a web of discursive arenas” spread across societal structures and sometimes the national and institutional borders between them (71). On platforms like Reddit and Discord, students weave together interconnected spaces by asking and responding in local discursive arenas, often by simply giving it away, letting themselves vent, or sharing common ground with their monikered peers. These activities are suggestive of the gift economy, peer production networks, and the promise of the knowledge commons before surveillance capitalism. Literacy work done by students in these spaces both take place within and beyond institutional power structures, and while individual interactions may be locally situated, there is good reason to describe these networked practices in terms of what Hauser deems a "reticulate Public Sphere,” where participants engage with and respond to strangers whose contributions they "heed and consider," collectively producing new forms of social and academic practice through their rhetorical exchanges (72). The networked character of student discourse in these spaces aligns with what Brunner and Raunig (2015) identify as the "micropolitical active power" of the undercommons, where knowledge sharing occurs through distributed yet interconnected channels rather than centralized institutional frameworks. The emergence of peer knowledge commons on Reddit and Discord can also be seen as a response to the increasing segmentation, scarcity of resources, and immobility within higher education systems, as per studies on educational access and social mobility (Citation A).

## Data Triangulation and Mixeds Ethnographic Methods

I frame this study in terms of data gathered from semi-structured interviews with participants who broker, repair, and maintain subreddit communities and Discord servers as networked digital communities for their student peers. These volunteer moderators manage the flow of discourse, enforce communal norms, and mediate conflicts, alongside the chatty posters, peer respondents, and occasional anonymous alumni who populate the threads. Their contributions are wide-ranging—alumni offering unfiltered advice based on lived experience; self-identified dropouts articulating critiques from the institutional periphery; and current students parsing out the minutiae of course selection, campus bureaucracy, and academic survival. Together, these perspectives provide a textured understanding of how these spaces function—not merely as forums for dialogue but as mechanisms for redistributing knowledge, resources, and solidarity.

I employ a range of semi-structured and freeform interview tactics to surface unexpected and authentic accounts of CUNY Reddit, interviewing alumni and student moderators whose labor sustains and organizes these communities. I also speak with responsive, reliable, or otherwise "chatty" posters to weigh the value of those intrepid peer respondents who keep the conversation alive until the morning. These voices vary widely, from anonymous alumni mentors who offer insider advice to self-identified dropouts who critique institutional failures from the margins. These perspectives provide a textured understanding of how CUNY students use digital platforms to navigate institutional constraints, negotiate power dynamics, and share knowledge in ways that formal institutional channels often fail to support. I leverage multiple scales of research and analysis to conduct my study of Reddit, combining interview data with mixed methods of distant reading and discourse analysis. I conduct this study at multiple scales of analysis to be mindful of the complexity and situatedness of social networking contributions to Reddit and Discord.

### Boss Texts: Official Discourse and Lived Discourse

Known as "boss texts" in institutional ethnography, these texts range from strategic plans and accreditation reports to syllabi and campus communications, and operate as manifestations of institutional authority, framing what "counts" as legitimate engagement and student-centered

learning. The lively and often vernacular exchanges on Reddit and Discord challenge these frameworks, demonstrating how students reimagine institutional norms and infrastructures through informal, networked collaboration. In response, I consider established genres of university communication and enforcement against in terms of student-authored posts and comment in subreddits ranging from r/CUNY to r/Baruch to r/CCNY. Placing institutional and vernacular discourses in tension, the work attends to how these student communities both contest and complement the institutional literacies mandated by CUNY's administrative apparatus, revealing the limits of "boss texts" through "thick descriptions" of students in need of support to survive—let alone alone thrive—within an underfunded urban university system, such as CUNY.

Gather institutional texts that appear in discussions — e.g. excerpts from student handbooks, official emails, assignment prompts — to help contextualize the online discourse in terms of the actual institutional artifacts students deal with. In IE, this approach involves comparing *official discourse* to *lived discourse* to determine where artifacts align or conflict, and why it matters.

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## Framing Paragraphs on Reddit and Discord

In today's digital age, online platforms have drastically reshaped the ways in which students access, share, and construct knowledge, with such platforms as Reddit and Discord exemplifying the diverse range of informal literacy practices that extend beyond traditional learning environs. While both platforms foster informal, self-directed learning, they do so through distinct modes of interaction and community governance: Reddit enables students to enter into composition with one another through asynchronous, community-moderated forums, as Discord affords real-time messaging and conversation in connected yet independent community servers.

When examining the role of subreddit communities in facilitating student navigation of their educational experiences, it is essential to understand the unique discursive practices that characterize these online spaces. As **Halavais (2020)** notes, Reddit's decentralized architecture creates a patchwork of distinct communities that resists easy generalization. This heterogeneous configuration makes Reddit a rich site for informal learning and peer support, particularly among students who share experiences, ask questions, and engage in discussions that shape their academic journeys. The concept of "learning in the wild," as articulated by **Kumar et al. (2018)**, further highlights how Redditors leverage specific subreddits—such as r/AskAcademia and r/AskHistorians—to pursue self-directed learning practices.

This informal learning environment is marked by a diverse array of interactions that can significantly influence students' educational navigation. The governance structures within subreddit communities play a crucial role in shaping discourse and interaction norms; **Fiesler et al. (2018)** highlight the importance of understanding how subreddit moderators establish rules that govern community interactions, while **Gillett and Suzor (2021)** reveal that community norms are influenced by both site-wide regulations and the specific cultural contexts of individual subreddits. Such interplay between moderation and community norms is particularly relevant for students who may encounter varying levels of support and incivility depending on the subreddit they engage with and the purposes for which their contributions are intended.

A similar yet distinct set of dynamics characterizes Discord—a platform originally designed for gamers that has found renewed purpose in educational contexts by providing spaces for real-time communication and community building. Discord facilitates a sense of community among

students, which is crucial for fostering collaborative learning experiences (**Craig and Kay 2023)**. Its design encourages informal interactions, allowing students to share resources, discuss course materials, and support one another in their educational journeys. This aligns with findings that suggest students prefer Discord over traditional communication tools like email or forums, as it promotes a more dynamic and engaging learning atmosphere **(Arifianto & Izzudin, 2021)**. Research by **Jannah and Hentasmaka (2021) and Ghazali (2023)** further indicates that integrating Discord into virtual learning environments improves students' perceptions of their educational experiences by providing a dedicated space for dialogue and interpersonal exchange. This need for discursive space speaks to the importance of synchronous communication practices on Discord, specifically in regard to how students articulate their educational needs and experiences through registers grounded in what **Papacharissi (2015)** describes as "digital orality." This form of communication is characterized by informal, expressive language that often includes hyperbolic expressions and rhetorical questioning, which serve to convey emotional responses to academic challenges. The informal tone of these interactions facilitates a supportive atmosphere where students can share their experiences and provide guidance to one another.

Digital orality manifests in multifaceted ways, particularly through the use of slang, abbreviations, memes, and jargon that reflect the vernacular of the students' immediate communities. This linguistic style not only reinforces a shared identity among students but also enhances their collective learning ethos; for instance, the use of digital storytelling in educational contexts has been shown to engage students and foster a sense of community, as evidenced by collaborative projects that leverage digital media. Such projects allow students to articulate their experiences in relatable ways, thereby enhancing their engagement and emotional connection to the material. Audience awareness represents another critical component of digital orality, as students adeptly navigate between informal and formal registers depending on their audience. Research indicates that students' ability to adapt their communication style based on audience awareness is crucial for successful interactions in both academic and social contexts.

The dynamic interplay of informal expression and strategic self-presentation in these digital spaces underscores the importance of digital orality as a communicative tool that fosters collaborative learning environments. In summary, digital orality serves as a vital mechanism

through which students articulate their educational needs and experiences. It is characterized by informal, expressive language and a strong sense of community, enabling peer support and resource sharing. This phenomenon is particularly evident on platforms like Reddit and Discord, where students engage in a rich tapestry of communication that blends personal narratives with collective learning practices.

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## Moderators

This section explores the community literacies of current and former moderators of subreddits related to the CUNY system, with secondary review of the Discord servers that serve as mirrors to such subreddit communities as r/CUNY, r/Baruch, r/QueensCollege, r/HunterCollege, r/CCNY, and more. Daily, if not weekly, volunteer moderators take what Warner describes as "the reflexive circulation of public discourse" (2006), not only crafting codes of conduct and enforcing them in static print, but also evaluating a regular stream of posts and comments from subreddit members.

I frame this study in terms of data gathered from semi-structured interviews with participants who broker, repair, and maintain subreddit communities and Discord servers as networked digital communities for their students peers. These volunteer moderators manage the flow of discourse, enforce communal norms, and mediate conflicts, alongside the chatty posters, peer respondents, and occasional anonymous alumni who populate the threads. Their contributions are wide-ranging: alumni offering unfiltered advice based on lived experience; self-identified dropouts articulating critiques from the institutional periphery; and current students parsing out the minutiae of course selection, campus bureaucracy, and academic survival. Together, these perspectives provide a textured understanding of how these spaces function—not merely as forums for dialogue but as mechanisms for redistributing knowledge, resources, and solidarity.

# Literature Reviews

# Digital Institutional Ethnography

I will adapt LeFrance's institutional ethnographic approach to examine how students develop literacy practices within Reddit and Discord communities, specifically focusing on r/CUNY, r/Baruch, and r/CCNY. This adaptation will integrate discourse analysis of subreddit discussions and think-aloud protocols with active contributors. The study will draw connections to boyd's (2017) ethnographic work on youth participation in networked digital spaces, examining how institutional structures and digital participation shape students' writing and knowledge-sharing practices. I will provide methodological recommendations, ethical considerations, and coding strategies for analyzing student literacy development in these digital spaces.

# Adapting Institutional Ethnography to Reddit and Discord Student Communities

## Institutional Ethnography in a Digital Context

Michelle LaFrance adapts Dorothy Smith's institutional ethnography (IE) to writing studies, emphasizing how texts coordinate people's work in institutional settings (Michelle LaFrance on her book, Institutional Ethnography – CaMP Anthropology). IE investigates how everyday practices (like writing and communicating) are shaped by larger institutional forces. It reveals *"the deep and often hidden investments and experiences"* of individuals, *"making visible the values, practices, [and] beliefs"* that underlie more dominant discourses (). In other words, it connects personal experiences to institutional power structures and policies. LaFrance's work shows that IE is well-suited to studying literacy in context – traditionally in classrooms or writing centers, but we can extend it to online student communities.

To adapt IE for Reddit and Discord, we treat these platforms as part of the institutional environment. Recent work argues that *digital platforms can be understood as institutions* themselves, with rules and algorithms that coordinate users' activities (Writing the Social Web: Toward an Institutional Ethnography for the Internet). Reddit subreddits (like r/CUNY, r/Baruch, r/CCNY) and college Discord servers have their own norms, moderators, and "texts" (posts, comments, rules) that shape how students interact. The institutional ethnographer would thus map how students' online writing

and interactions are influenced by: (1) University structures (e.g. CUNY policies, college culture, "official" information circulating), and (2) Platform structures (Reddit/Discord norms, moderation, ranking systems). By viewing the subreddit and Discord communities as extensions of the university's social world, we can examine how institutional power and expectations filter into peer-to-peer online conversations. For example, a pinned subreddit rule or a Discord channel guideline can function like a "boss text" (an authoritative text) that coordinates how students seek advice or share knowledge, much as a syllabus or policy document would in a classroom. The goal of an IE approach here is to trace connections between what students do and say online and the institutional relations that shape those actions (academic requirements, administrative processes, platform governance, etc.).

Within these communities, students develop literacy practices by engaging in informal discussion, Q&A, and knowledge-sharing. "Literacy" here includes not only reading/writing skills, but also knowing the community's language, norms, and how to effectively communicate to get help. Adapting LaFrance's approach means starting from the students' standpoint – their experiences as CUNY students seeking information or camaraderie on Reddit/Discord – and analyzing how their writing practices (asking questions, telling stories, giving advice) are socially organized. We might document how a student learns to write a post that will get helpful responses (e.g. using the right format or terminology), or how they interpret and respond to institutional jargon (like financial aid terms or course codes) that appear in these forums. By mapping these practices, the researcher uncovers how institutional power structures (like university bureaucracy or moderation rules) and community norms shape *what* and *how* students write in these digital spaces.

## Discourse Analysis of Subreddit Discussions

To examine literacy practices, we would collect and analyze discussion threads from **r/CUNY, r/Baruch, and r/CCNY** (and parallel Discord chat logs if available). Using **discourse analysis**, the researcher looks for patterns in language, content, and interaction.

Key steps include:

- **Data Collection:** Gather a corpus of posts and comments over a period of time or on specific recurring topics (e.g. posts about registration, writing assignments, professor reviews, etc.). This can be done via the Reddit API or manual archiving, ensuring we have the context of each

conversation. On Discord, one might join the server (with permission) and observe or log discussions in relevant channels (e.g. a #homework-help channel). It's important to note differences: Reddit threads are typically question-and-answer format with persistent posts, whereas Discord is more real-time chat – we may treat lengthy Discord message exchanges similarly to forum threads for analysis.

- **Analyzing Linguistic Norms:** Identify the community's linguistic norms and writing conventions. For instance, do students use CUNY-specific jargon or abbreviations? (Likely yes – e.g. referring to "FINAID" for financial aid or using course codes like ENG 2100). Is the tone formal, or more casual and meme-inflected? (Student subreddits tend to be informal, using slang, emojis, and inside jokes). Discourse analysis will note features like code-switching (perhaps switching between academic language and internet slang), politeness strategies (how they ask for help or thank others), and any genre conventions (like the common format for asking for professor recommendations or the norm of tagging posts by category). These linguistic practices show how students adapt their writing to fit the peer community, which is a key part of their digital literacy development.

- **Examining Content and Knowledge-Sharing:** The content of posts will often revolve around institutional processes ("How do I register for X?", "Has anyone taken Professor Y?") and personal experiences. By analyzing these discussions, we see how students collectively construct knowledge about navigating college. For example, one student might write a detailed guide on how to find open classes or a step-by-step solution to a common problem, effectively mentoring others through text. The discourse analysis looks at how information is presented and responded to: Do students provide sources or links (e.g. linking to a CUNY policy page or a previous thread)? Do they narrate personal anecdotes as advice? We also pay attention to **interaction patterns** – who tends to answer questions (experienced students, alumni?), and how newcomers are treated (welcomed, or told to "read the FAQ"?). Patterns of encouragement or gatekeeping reflect the community's culture of support (or lack thereof).

- **Institutional Power in Discourse:** As part of IE, we specifically look in the discourse for traces of institutional power relations. This might include references to authoritative texts or figures (university emails, administrators, department rules) and how students talk about them. For instance, a thread about resolving an issue with the registrar might reveal how students perceive university bureaucracy – perhaps sharing tactics to "get someone on the phone" or expressing frustration at a lack of transparency. We analyze **power dynamics** in conversations: Are there instances where someone positions themselves as an authority (e.g. a moderator enforcing rules, or a student worker sharing insider knowledge)? How do students *resist* or *accommodate* institutional norms in their writing? (Maybe joking about policies, or carefully formatting a complaint to be taken seriously by admin if they read it). This aligns with IE's interest in *"looking up power gradients"* to see how official policies or hierarchies shape the everyday exchanges (). For example, if a student shares *"According to the student handbook, we have the right to appeal a grade"* and then others discuss how to write an appeal letter, we witness an interaction between institutional text and student practice.

Through discourse analysis, the project also documents the literacy practices in situ: how students write to each other, the community-specific language they learn, and the way knowledge is collaboratively built. These findings will inform how we understand student writing development outside the classroom. Moreover, by comparing **subreddits vs. Discord**, we might note differences in discourse. Reddit posts are semi-public and archived; students might put more effort into making them clear and search-friendly (knowing posts persist). Discord chats, being more ephemeral within a closed group, might encourage even more casual speech or rapid Q&A exchanges. Both forms together give a richer picture of students' digital literacy environment.

## Think-Aloud Protocols with Active Contributors

To complement online observation, we incorporate **think-aloud protocols** with select participants. Think-aloud is a method where individuals verbalize their thoughts in real time while performing a task. Here, the task is writing or responding in the online community. This approach provides insight into the *writing process and decision-making* that isn't directly visible from the final posts.

**Implementing Think-Alouds:** We would recruit active contributors from the subreddits or Discord (with their consent). "Active" could mean students who frequently post or answer questions (possibly identified through the subreddit or by referral). Each participant might be asked to complete one or two typical community activities while speaking their thoughts. For example:

- Composing a new Reddit post (perhaps the participant has an actual question or topic they want to post, or we give a prompt scenario like "imagine you want to ask advice about course selection on r/Baruch"). As they write the title and body, they narrate why they phrase things a certain way (*"I'll mention I'm a freshman so they know my context"*, *"Not going to use my name, I prefer to stay anonymous"*, *"I remember there's a rule about no professor bashing, so I'll be polite in how I ask about Professor X"*, etc.). This reveals how the writer takes the audience and subreddit norms into account – a key aspect of literacy practice.

- Responding to someone else's post or a Discord question. The participant could scroll a subreddit, find a question they feel knowledgeable about (say, *"How do I fulfill requirement Y?"*), and then type out a reply while talking through it. We'd learn how they decide what information to include (*"I'll link the academic calendar here because that has the deadlines"*), what tone to use (*"I don't want to sound condescending, so I'll add 'hope this helps!' at the end"*), and how they draw on their own experience or memory of past discussions.

Each think-aloud session would be recorded (audio or video capturing the screen, if possible) and transcribed for analysis.

**Insights from Think-Alouds:** Analyzing these protocols can illuminate the *knowledge-sharing strategies* and writing skills students develop. We might discover, for instance, that students internally consider multiple audiences: the person asking, the broader community who might read later, and even institutional watchers (some might say, *"I have to be careful not to violate any rules or the post might get removed by mods"* – indicating awareness of moderation, a form of power in the space). Think-alouds also show the *intertextuality* in their writing process: students might recall prior posts or external sources as they formulate answers (e.g. *"I remember a Google doc circulating with internship opportunities – I'll find that link"*). This speaks to their information literacy and how the community

fosters it. By capturing these thought processes, the researcher gains a deeper understanding of **why** students write the way they do on these platforms, complementing the **what** we see in discourse analysis. It links the observable literacy practice to the cognitive and social intentions behind it. For example, a student might reveal that they deliberately use a lot of abbreviations or a casual tone *because* they feel it's the norm on Discord – which is evidence of them adapting to a linguistic norm (and perhaps how that norm socializes their writing style).

Combining think-aloud data with the discourse analysis provides a robust picture: we see both the final texts in context and the individual process of composition. This mixed-method approach strengthens the institutional ethnography by ensuring we remain grounded in participants' perspectives (a core IE principle). It's akin to doing an interview but with a focus on an active writing event, yielding rich data on community-informed writing practices.

## Connecting to boyd's Ethnographic Insights on Networked Youth

danah boyd's work (2017) on youth participation in networked digital spaces offers a valuable lens to interpret our findings. Boyd studied how teenagers use social network sites as "networked publics" – essentially online spaces that function similarly to physical public spaces for youth culture ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life). College students on r/CUNY, r/Baruch, and r/CCNY are a bit older than boyd's teens, but their use of Reddit and Discord echoes many of boyd's observations:

- **Networked Publics & Peer Culture:** Just as boyd found that teens *"use networked publics to gather, socialize with their peers, and make sense of and help build the culture around them"* ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life), CUNY students are using Reddit and Discord to create a peer-driven support culture. These subreddits/servers are the digital equivalent of the campus quad or student lounge – places to hang out, vent, seek advice, and form community ties. Our adaptation of IE acknowledges this by situating literacy practices in the context of an *online public* shaped by youth participation. The *culture* being built in these forums (inside jokes about campus life, norms of helping one another, meme-based expressions of student life) is an important part of student literacy. It's an emergent, youth-led culture, much like boyd's networked teens creating

their own online social norms ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life).

- **Properties of the Digital Space:** Boyd highlights how features like *persistence, searchability, replicability,* and *invisible audiences* affect how young people interact online ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life). These are highly relevant to Reddit/Discord literacy practices:

    - *Persistence/Searchability:* Reddit threads persist over time; a question asked this semester might be searched by another student next semester. Students may be aware of this and thus write posts that will be clear to future readers (e.g. updating a post with a [Resolved] tag or summary). Discord is less searchable, but important info may be pinned by moderators for longevity. Our discourse analysis would look for evidence that students understand this persistence (for instance, referencing earlier threads or telling newcomers to "search the subreddit first"). This aligns with boyd's finding that youth *recognize these structural properties and find ways to make these systems serve their purposes* ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life) – CUNY students might create FAQ threads or compilation posts to aggregate knowledge, effectively leveraging the platform's affordances for community memory.
    - *Invisible Audiences:* On an open subreddit, students write without knowing exactly who will read – could be peers, professors, or strangers. Boyd notes that online contributors often contend with unseen audiences, which influences *impression management*. In our context, a student might post anonymously or use a throwaway account when discussing a sensitive topic (e.g. mental health or a complaint about a professor), indicating awareness that anyone (even an authority) could be reading. This is a savvy literacy practice regarding privacy and self-presentation, directly echoing issues boyd documented (teens managing what they share knowing parents or others might see). We will be attentive to such behaviors and rationales (perhaps elicited in

think-alouds or follow-up interviews: *"I'm using a pseudonym here because I don't want this tied to my real name"*).

- *Peer-driven innovation:* Boyd's ethnography showed that youth find innovative ways to exploit technology for their needs ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life). Similarly, we expect to see students appropriating Reddit/Discord in creative ways to support their learning. For example, they might create a bot on Discord that answers frequently asked questions, or use Reddit's polling feature to gather opinions on a course. Recognizing these as literacy practices (writing code or crafting surveys as part of community participation) broadens our understanding of "student literacy" in networked spaces. It demonstrates, as boyd would suggest, youth agency in making the platform work for them.

Overall, connecting to boyd's work helps frame our study in a broader narrative of **networked youth engagement**. It assures us that studying these online communities is not isolating an odd phenomenon, but rather tapping into how modern students naturally extend their social and learning activities online. It also reminds us to consider the **historical and social context**: boyd situated teens' online participation in the context of their restricted offline freedom ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life). In the college context, students might turn to Reddit/Discord because official channels are lacking or slow; the networked community might fill gaps left by institutional support, or simply offer a more accessible, peer-friendly venue. This perspective will inform how we interpret the role of these digital spaces in shaping student literacy – often these spaces *empower* students to share knowledge in ways the formal institution does not.

## Methodological Recommendations for Online Institutional Ethnography

When conducting an institutional ethnography in online environments like Reddit and Discord, a careful, multi-faceted research design is needed. Below are key methodological recommendations:

1. **Define the Scope and Standpoint:** Clearly identify the communities (field sites) and whose experiences you center. For instance, our focus is the student experience within r/CUNY, r/Baruch, r/CCNY, and related Discords. We take the *student contributors' standpoint* as the point of entry (consistent with IE's principle of starting from the standpoint of the people involved, not the top of the institution). This means our questions and observations prioritize student concerns (e.g. "How do students navigate institutional processes through these forums?"). We might limit the scope to specific types of literacy events – e.g. how students learn to write academically, how they get help with writing assignments, or more broadly any kind of informational writing on these platforms.

2. **Participant-Observation in Online Communities:** Engage with the subreddit and Discord communities to build contextual knowledge. This can involve **lurking** (observing without actively participating) to see typical interactions, as well as possibly **light participation** (asking or answering a question occasionally) if appropriate and ethically cleared. The researcher could create a researcher persona or disclose their presence if required. Observing over time helps note rhythms (e.g. more activity at semester start or during exams) and insider references. Keep detailed field notes of observations, just as in an in-person ethnography. Note the "texts" that matter in the community: subreddit rules, wiki/FAQ pages, pinned Discord messages, etc., since IE is very concerned with key texts that mediate action.

3. **Data Triangulation:** Combine multiple data sources to enrich the ethnographic picture:

    - **Archival Data:** Systematically collect threads from the subreddits (and logs from Discord if possible). This forms the basis for discourse analysis. Given the volume, you might sample strategically (e.g. top posts of each month, or threads about particular recurrent issues such as freshman advice, or all threads mentioning "writing" or "essay" to focus on academic literacy).
    - **Elicitation and Interviews:** In addition to think-aloud sessions, consider follow-up interviews or written questionnaires with participants to clarify their perspectives. For

example, after a think-aloud, ask questions like *"I noticed you phrased your post very formally; can you tell me why?"* to get at their intent or any influence from institutional norms (maybe they felt they had to sound "professional" to get a serious response).

- **Institutional Documents:** Gather relevant institutional texts that appear in discussions – e.g. excerpts from student handbooks, official emails, assignment prompts (if students share them). This helps connect the online discourse to the actual institutional artifacts students deal with. In IE, comparing the *official discourse* to the *lived discourse* is illuminating (where do they align or conflict?).

4. **Discourse Analysis Techniques:** Use discourse analytic methods appropriate for online text.

   This might involve coding transcripts of threads for themes (more on coding below), as well as closer analysis of language in use. You can draw on techniques from **critical discourse analysis** (to see how power/identity manifest in language) or **genre analysis** (to see if a Reddit post follows a certain structure like a mini-genre of "asking for advice"). Pay attention to interactional elements: turn-taking (who answers first, do replies get acknowledgment), the use of Reddit's scoring (do highly upvoted comments set a norm or consensus?), and how narratives are constructed. For Discord, one might utilize **conversation analysis** elements because of the synchronous nature (e.g. how quickly do people get a response, do they use @mentions for knowledgeable people, etc.). Throughout, maintain an **IE lens**: keep asking how what you see relates to institutional processes or contexts. For example, if many threads are students complaining about advising, that points to an institutional gap; the ethnographer might then investigate the advising system (outside the scope of online data) to understand what drives those complaints.

5. **Think-Aloud Integration:** Schedule and conduct think-aloud sessions as described earlier.

   As a recommendation, pilot this method with one participant first to refine the prompts and setup. It can be challenging for participants to verbalize while typing, so be flexible – some might prefer to draft a post and then *retrospectively* walk you through their thought process. Ensure these sessions are as comfortable as possible (perhaps done via screen-share on Zoom for convenience). Triangulate the think-aloud findings with what you see in the naturally occurring data. For instance, if a think-aloud reveals that a student decided not to use a certain

word to avoid sounding "dumb," check if vocabulary use correlates with any observable pattern in the threads.

6. **Iterative Refocus:** Institutional ethnography often involves following threads of data that lead outside the initial site. Be prepared for your online observations to raise new questions. If students constantly refer to a specific college policy, you might need to examine that policy document and maybe even talk to an administrator (if feasible) to fully map the relationship. While our main sites are Reddit/Discord, the "institution" in institutional ethnography may pull us into offline or official domains as well. Methodologically, remain open to adjusting your focus to follow the connections that participants themselves make in their literacy practices.

By following these recommendations, the study will be grounded, comprehensive, and true to the spirit of IE (which values *emic* perspective – understanding the community on its own terms – and then connecting it to the broader structure).

## Ethical Considerations in Online Ethnography

Researching online student communities requires careful ethical planning. Key considerations include:

- **Informed Consent and Transparency:** Even though subreddits like r/CUNY are public forums, it is good practice to inform the community of the research when possible. One approach is to contact the subreddit moderators, explain the study, and ask permission to post a short recruitment or information message. The same goes for Discord – Discord servers often have rules against data scraping or lurking for research, so obtain permission from server admins. For the think-aloud portion and any interviews, obtain **informed consent** from each participant (explaining the study's purpose, what data will be collected, and how it will be used). They should know they can withdraw at any time.

- **Privacy and Anonymity:** Protecting participant identity is crucial. Reddit usernames are often pseudonymous, but they still could be linked to a real person. In publications or reports,

**anonymize quotes** (use pseudonyms or just "Reddit user 1") and avoid any details that could easily identify someone (for example, if a user's handle is literally "Baruch_JohnDoe2025", you wouldn't quote that). If quoting direct posts, you might even consider paraphrasing or obtaining consent from the author if the content is sensitive. However, public posts are generally considered fair to use as data without individual consent as long as they're anonymized (Ethics in using Reddit for academic purposes. : r/AskAcademia). Still, err on the side of caution for students' privacy – these communities might feel intimate to them even if technically public.

- **No Harm to Participants:** Be mindful that these forums might contain personal or emotionally charged content (students seeking mental health advice, venting about stress, etc.). Treat such data with sensitivity. In write-ups, contextualize rather than sensationalize difficulties students share. Also consider the potential impact on the community: if you publish findings that are critical of the university, could it backfire on the students who provided the info? Likely not if anonymity is preserved, but be aware of **power dynamics** – the university is part of the audience of this research too. Ensuring students can speak freely without repercussion means the researcher must safeguard their identities and any identifiable data.

- **IRB and Ethical Approval:** Institutional Review Boards often consider publicly available online data as *not human subjects research* if no intervention or private info is involved. As one scholar noted, analyzing posts on a public site like Reddit is often "fair play" since users have *"no expectation of privacy"* and content is publicly archived (Ethics in using Reddit for academic purposes. : r/AskAcademia). However, when combined with direct interaction (think-alouds, interviews), this definitely becomes human subjects research. Prepare an IRB application detailing how you will recruit participants (e.g. via subreddit post or DM, making it clear that participation is voluntary and unrelated to their standing in school), how you will store data securely, and how you will handle any sensitive information. The IRB will also want to know if you plan to conceal your identity in the field or not – deception is generally discouraged, so it's better to be upfront in your online profile that you're a researcher (even if you're mostly lurking). Following **AoIR (Association of Internet Researchers) guidelines**

for ethical online research is recommended, which stress contextual integrity and respecting community norms (Ethics in using Reddit for academic purposes. : r/AskAcademia).

- **Moderation and Community Consent:** One ethical aspect specific to these communities is respecting the moderators and rules. If a subreddit has a rule "Don't survey our users without mod approval," you must adhere to that. On Discord, if the server is invite-only or has a closed membership, treat it as a private space where users have a higher expectation of privacy. You might need to obtain consent from all members (impractical) or more realistically, limit your data collection to what you can ethically justify (maybe focus on general, non-sensitive discussions). In some cases, researchers negotiate a compromise, like only using data from a Discord channel designated for public info or getting an announcement posted that "this server is being observed for a study" so users are informed.

- **Data Security:** Store the collected data (posts, transcripts) on encrypted devices or secure drives. When working with transcripts of think-alouds, remove any real names or personal details mentioned. If a participant shows you something private during think-aloud (e.g. their unpublished draft or a private message), handle that with strict confidentiality and possibly exclude it from transcripts if not essential.

By addressing these ethical points, the research will respect the community and participants, maintaining trust. This is important not only morally but also pragmatically – a community that feels betrayed or scrutinized unethically could shut down access or even delete content, harming both the people and the research endeavor.

## Coding and Data Analysis Strategies

After collecting rich qualitative data (online posts, observation notes, think-aloud transcripts, etc.), the next step is making sense of it through coding and analysis. Here are strategies to guide this process:

- **Develop a Coding Scheme Aligned with IE:** Start with open coding – read through a sample of the data and note emergent categories without a strict predefined codebook. Given our focus, likely code categories will include: **Topics** (e.g. advising, coursework, social life, admin issues), **Practices** (e.g. asking for help, giving advice, sharing resources, humor/memes), **Institutional References** (mentions of rules, offices, professors), **Emotions/Attitudes** (frustration, solidarity, etc.), **Linguistic Features** (slang, formal tone, code-mixing), and **Power Dynamics** (instances of authority or conflict). Because IE is about connecting micro to macro, pay special attention to anything that links the personal story to a bigger structure – for example, a code for "policy navigation" whenever a student post describes how they navigated a bureaucracy, or "moderator intervention" when a mod steps in (signaling community power structure).

- **Iterative Coding (Constant Comparison):** As you code more data, refine and add codes as needed. Use the constant comparative method – compare each incident in the data with previous ones coded in the same category to refine your understanding. For instance, if you have a code "academic literacy" and you've been tagging instances where students discuss writing or studying strategies, compare those instances: are there sub-themes (like "plagiarism concerns" versus "finding research sources")? This could lead to sub-codes or new codes that better capture patterns.

- **Coding for Institutional Power Structures:** To address the research question about power, include codes that mark power relationships or institutional influences. You might code any mention of **official authority** (e.g. "the registrar," "professor X said…"), **policy** ("the deadline is set by CUNY"), or **resistance** (students pushing back, like "I filed a complaint"). Also code **moderation** instances in the subreddit/Discord (like "[Mod Removed]" comments or users referencing the rules). Once coded, you can analyze these segments to see how power is exercised or discussed. For example, you might find that students often share *workarounds* to institutional rules – those would be coded as both "resistance" and something like "informal knowledge." Using IE terms, you might think of this as mapping the **"ruling relations"** – how official systems (grading, financial aid, etc.) are present in the discourse and how students

respond to them.

- **Coding for Linguistic Norms and Styles:** In line with the interest in linguistic norms, track things like use of **abbreviations** (e.g. "Tbh" for *to be honest*, or campus-specific acronyms like "VC" for a building name), **memes or inside jokes**, **tone** (sarcastic, respectful, etc.). You could have a code for "informal language" vs "formal language" to later examine where and why each is used – maybe students use a very **formal register** when addressing certain topics (like asking for career advice, they might write more formally, almost like a cover letter in tone) versus very **informal** when gossiping or venting. These codes help in analyzing how participation in these spaces might be teaching students to *code-switch* between different English registers, an important literacy skill.

- **Software and Organizing Data:** Consider using qualitative analysis software (NVivo, Atlas.ti, Dedoose, or even a well-organized spreadsheet) to manage the coding. Import Reddit posts (perhaps as text or PDF exports) and transcripts of think-aloud sessions. Tag segments with multiple codes if applicable. IE often involves a lot of data, so being able to query the data (e.g., show all instances coded "moderator" and "advice given") can be very useful. For example, you might query all posts that mention "advisor" or "advising" to see how students talk about that institutional role, and whether the advice given is accurate per official policy – this could reveal gaps in institutional communication.

- **From Codes to Analysis**: After coding, move to higher-level analysis. Look for themes and patterns. For instance, you might find a theme of **"Peer mentorship literacy"** – students taking on mentoring roles for each other, which connects to both literacy development (students practicing explanatory writing) and institutional critique (they're filling a mentoring gap the college might not provide). Another theme could be **"Institutional literacy"** – how students collectively learn the bureaucratic language/forms of the university (a form of literacy!) through these discussions. Relate these themes back to your research questions and theoretical frames. Does the data support what LaFrance's institutional ethnography would predict, or boyd's observations? Maybe you find that digital spaces actually flatten some power

hierarchies – e.g. a freshman can correct a senior if they have the right info, because on Reddit credibility comes from knowledge, not status. That could be an interesting insight about power dynamics unique to the online medium.

- **Coding the Think-Alouds:** Don't forget to integrate the think-aloud transcripts into the coding process. Codes for think-alouds might include **"audience awareness"** (whenever the participant references who will read the post), **"community norm awareness"** (e.g. "I recall the rules allow this kind of post"), **"writing strategy"** (like planning, revising, choosing a title), and **"affect"** (signs of anxiety or confidence while writing). Comparing these to the actual posted text (if they did post it) is enlightening – did the articulated thought make it into the final post or get changed? This can show the *self-editing literacy* that students employ. For knowledge-sharing, if a participant says "I learned this trick from someone on the Discord last year," that indicates the spread of tacit knowledge through the community – something to note as a finding.

- **Memo Writing:** Throughout coding, write **analytic memos** to yourself. For example, after coding a batch of posts about *registration problems*, write a memo summarizing how students approach this issue and any institutional factors (e.g. "Many students mention the CUNYfirst system; they often share screenshots – indicates visual literacy and also perhaps lack of clear official guidance, leading to peer tutoring"). Memos help in the later stages when formulating arguments, ensuring you capture the contextual richness that pure codes might strip away.

- **Validity Checks:** In qualitative research, especially ethnography, it's good to ensure your interpretations are not off-base. Consider sharing some preliminary findings or themes with either participants or colleagues for a "member check" or peer debrief. For instance, you could present a summary of "Here's what I think is unique about how Baruch students use Reddit" to a couple of student participants and ask if that resonates or if you missed something. Their feedback can refine your coding categories or analysis.

By following these coding strategies, the analysis will systematically address how institutional power, linguistic norms, and digital space affordances intersect to shape student literacy practices. The coding process in an institutional ethnography is not just about categorizing data, but about assembling a narrative of how different layers of context connect. For example, you might literally map out (as a visual diagram) how a single Reddit thread about *"professor recommendations"* connects a student's personal writing (the post), the community's response (comments), and the institution's influence (the underlying concern is fulfilling a degree requirement, which is institutional). Such mapping is a hallmark of IE and can be greatly aided by the careful coding and organization of data described above.

## Addressing Power, Language, and Digital Influence in Conclusions

Finally, ensure that the study's conclusions explicitly tie back to the themes of **institutional power structures**, **linguistic norms**, and **the role of digital spaces in shaping literacy** (as the question asks to address these). Based on the above methods, the researcher will be able to discuss, for example:

- How **institutional power structures** (university bureaucracy, moderator authority, platform rules) are navigated and sometimes subverted by students' literacy practices. Perhaps the study finds that students create their own "power" through collective knowledge, somewhat leveling the field with the institution by making information accessible to peers. This would echo LaFrance's point that IE can reveal hidden dynamics and possibly opportunities for *"recognition or intervention"* () – maybe highlighting a need for the university to pay attention to these student-run knowledge networks.

- What **linguistic norms** characterize these communities and how participating in them develops new literacies. For instance, students learn a kind of *genre* – the "Reddit academic help post" – which has a certain style that is quite different from an email to a professor. This dual audience (peer forum vs. formal academic) might actually improve students' ability to adjust register and tone depending on context. The research could show that digital slang and academic terminology coexist in students' repertoire, indicating an expanding literacy skill set.

- The **role of digital spaces** in shaping student literacy is likely significant. These platforms encourage brevity and clarity (due to attention economy and norms of getting to the point), so students may become better at concise explanation. They also expose students to diverse perspectives (someone from another CUNY campus might chime in, broadening a student's knowledge beyond their own college). As boyd (2017) noted, youth are *"making these systems serve their purposes"* ((PDF) Why Youth (Heart) Social Network Sites: The Role of Networked Publics in Teenage Social Life) – here, CUNY students repurpose social platforms for academic and social support, which in turn shapes how they write, how they seek information, and how they see themselves as learners. We can conclude that this self-directed, peer-based literacy practice is an important complement to formal education. Institutional ethnography helps illuminate this by situating these seemingly casual interactions as a meaningful part of the educational ecosystem – one that faculty and administrators might do well to recognize and engage with, rather than ignore.

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# Peer Knowledge Commons

# Peer Knowledge Commons: Literature Review

## Introduction

The emergence of *peer knowledge commons* in the digital age has enabled volunteers and distributed communities to collaboratively produce and share information as a public good. Commons-based peer production, a term popularized by Yochai Benkler, refers to decentralized creation of knowledge and cultural goods by self-organizing communities of peers (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). This model prioritizes open sharing of information and harnesses human altruism and cooperation to connect individuals in collaboration without traditional hierarchical structures (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). Social networking platforms have become important arenas for such peer production, allowing user communities to assemble, exchange knowledge, and build commons resources (e.g. Wikipedia, open-source projects) at unprecedented scale. However, these same platforms also pose challenges for knowledge commons – from algorithm-driven echo chambers to the spread of misinformation.

When the COVID-19 pandemic struck in early 2020, it upended global information practices and tested the resilience of peer knowledge commons. Lockdowns and social distancing shifted much of human interaction online, dramatically increasing reliance on digital platforms for both factual updates and collaborative problem-solving. An accompanying "infodemic" of false information (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core) further complicated the landscape, forcing platforms and communities to adapt their governance and moderation strategies. This historical review traces the development of peer knowledge commons *during and after the COVID-19 pandemic*, examining how knowledge-sharing practices evolved, how social networking platforms both fostered and hindered commons-based peer production, and the key trends in community-driven knowledge initiatives that emerged. We also consider shifts in platform

governance – including content moderation policies and algorithmic interventions – that shaped these developments, drawing on case studies and scholarly debates for insight.

## Peer Knowledge Commons and Social Networks: Pre-Pandemic Context

Prior to the pandemic, various forms of peer-produced knowledge commons were already well established online. Wikipedia, for example, had grown into the world's largest encyclopedia through millions of volunteer edits, illustrating the power of decentralized collaboration ( Volunteer contributions to Wikipedia increased during COVID-19 mobility restrictions - PMC ). Open-source software communities, open data initiatives, and peer-to-peer forums similarly demonstrated that networked publics could create and curate valuable knowledge resources. Social media platforms played an increasingly important role in this ecosystem by connecting experts, enthusiasts, and laypeople across the globe. On Twitter and Reddit, niche communities (e.g. "Science Twitter" or specialist subreddits) enabled rapid sharing of research findings, tutorials, and collective discussions. Facebook groups and other forums gathered practitioners to swap knowledge in fields from coding to healthcare. In essence, the infrastructure for commons-based peer production was in place – a *digital commons* where information is non-rivalrous and accessible to all participants (The Commons: More than just resources).

Even before 2020, however, cracks in the information environment were evident. Misinformation and disinformation on social networks had impacted public discourse on issues like vaccination and climate change. Researchers warned that algorithms optimized for engagement often amplified divisive or false content, undermining the quality of shared knowledge (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech). For instance, Facebook's own studies acknowledged that its recommendation algorithms tended to boost extreme or conspiratorial material (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech). Still, the pre-pandemic years saw growing awareness of the need to bolster online knowledge commons – through better platform design, community moderation, and open access policies – to serve the public interest. This set the stage for the COVID-19 era, when effective knowledge sharing became a matter of life and death.

## Knowledge Sharing Under the Pandemic: Evolution of Practices

The COVID-19 pandemic dramatically accelerated *open knowledge-sharing practices* and highlighted the value of peer-produced commons. Faced with a fast-moving novel virus, researchers and health professionals turned to open science in unprecedented ways. There was a surge of collaboration and data-sharing: scientists worldwide posted preliminary findings as preprints, shared datasets, and pooled expertise in real time. Major publishers and journals temporarily dropped paywalls, opening access to thousands of COVID-related research articles for all to read (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO). This rapid openness allowed teams across the globe to keep up with research advances and hasten their own work, illustrating how treating knowledge as a commons can speed innovation (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO). Data and metadata about the virus (genomic sequences, case statistics, etc.) were broadly disseminated, escaping the usual confines of proprietary control (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO). In short, the pandemic "allowed us to observe a great surge of collaboration and sharing of scientific knowledge," as one UNESCO review noted (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO). Many dubbed this a renaissance of open science, rekindling arguments that free flow of information is crucial in tackling global crises (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core).

Everyday knowledge-sharing practices also evolved as in-person contact waned. Professionals and citizens alike flocked to social networking platforms for real-time updates, expert advice, and community support. *Twitter became a de facto hub for scientific communication*: researchers, epidemiologists, and data analysts used threads and tweets to interpret new data and debate public health measures in real time. One analysis observed that Twitter enabled *global communication between scientists on a scale not seen before*, allowing rapid exchange of insights (as well as criticisms) during the outbreak ( Social Media and the New World of Scientific Communication During the COVID-19 Pandemic - PMC ). This real-time, crowdsourced approach to science communication – while *"a double-edged sword"* – filled a gap left by slower traditional channels ( Social Media and the New World of Scientific Communication During the COVID-19 Pandemic - PMC ) ( Social Media and the New World of Scientific Communication During the COVID-19 Pandemic - PMC ). Meanwhile, Reddit communities like r/Coronavirus exploded in size, facilitating long-form discussion, Q&A with experts,

and aggregation of news. Public-facing initiatives such as Ask Me Anything (AMA) sessions on Reddit connected users with virologists and healthcare workers, helping disseminate trusted knowledge directly (Misinformation and COVID-19: What Reddit is Doing : r/ModSupport). In these ways, digital platforms fostered new modes of peer learning and support, from local Facebook support groups to international forums for medical professionals. Knowledge commons became not only an intellectual endeavor but a practical toolkit for resilience – for example, communities sharing tips on remote teaching, mental health, or DIY sanitization methods.

At the same time, the pandemic's social media landscape was mired in an "infodemic" – an overabundance of misinformation that threatened to derail the collective understanding needed to combat COVID-19. The World Health Organization warned of an infodemic where conspiracy theories, rumors, and false cures spread virally online. Indeed, the *hyper-connected social media world of 2020* gave "rise to grave problems of misinformation on many aspects of the pandemic" (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). Dubious claims – from denying the virus's existence to promoting unproven treatments like drinking bleach – circulated widely. Anti-vaccine communities that predated COVID swelled in influence, now joined by new groups questioning masks or lockdowns. The result was a fractured information environment in which authoritative guidance often struggled to be heard above the noise (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). Scientific knowledge became politicized and weaponized, leading to public confusion and erosion of trust (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). In short, alongside the flourishing of open collaboration came the *challenge of quality control* and trust in the peer-produced knowledge commons. This dynamic – increased reliance on communal knowledge, yet increased exposure to falsehoods – defined the COVID-era knowledge-sharing experience.

## Community-Driven Knowledge Initiatives: Case Studies

Amid the turmoil, numerous community-driven initiatives demonstrated the strength and agility of peer production and the knowledge commons ethos. These case studies highlight how self-organized

networks of volunteers, often coordinated via social media, stepped up to meet information needs where institutions fell short:

- Wikipedia's COVID-19 Response: The volunteer editor community of Wikipedia responded with remarkable speed and resilience to the pandemic. As global readership of health topics spiked, Wikipedians massively ramped up their contributions. One study found that *Wikipedia's community substantially increased its productivity*, with edit volumes in 2020 far exceeding expectations based on pre-pandemic trends ( Volunteer contributions to Wikipedia increased during COVID-19 mobility restrictions - PMC ). By mid-2020, Wikipedia had over 5,000 COVID-related articles across 174 languages (WHO, Wikipedia partner to fight COVID-19 misinformation ), frequently updated in near real-time. To ensure accuracy, editors implemented stricter governance: from March 2020, all COVID-19 pages on English Wikipedia were placed under discretionary sanctions and heightened moderation (COVID-19 research in Wikipedia | Quantitative Science Studies). The Wikimedia Foundation even partnered with the WHO to incorporate official information – for example, uploading WHO "Mythbusters" infographics into Wikimedia Commons for use in articles (WHO, Wikipedia partner to fight COVID-19 misinformation ) (WHO, Wikipedia partner to fight COVID-19 misinformation ). Certain highly visible pages were locked for editing until vetted by experienced volunteers, including doctors and academics in WikiProject COVID-19 (WHO, Wikipedia partner to fight COVID-19 misinformation ). This combination of rapid peer production and cautious moderation allowed Wikipedia to emerge as a widely trusted source during the pandemic ( Volunteer contributions to Wikipedia increased during COVID-19 mobility restrictions - PMC ). It exemplified how a global knowledge commons could rise to the challenge of an evolving crisis.

- Open Source Medical Supplies (OSMS): When severe PPE shortages struck hospitals in 2020, a global maker community formed virtually to design and produce open-source medical gear. Open Source Medical Supplies (OSMS) began as an impromptu Facebook group and blossomed into a 73,000-member collaboration network ( Socialized leadership and improvisational responding to COVID-19 supply voids - PMC ). Through Facebook posts and Slack channels, engineers, medical professionals, and hobbyists from around the world

co-created designs for face shields, masks, ventilator parts, and more – all freely shared. This *"global hackathon"* of 2020 saw decentralized volunteers prototyping equipment locally with 3D printers and makerspaces (Rethinking intellectual property rights and commons-based peer production in times of crisis: The case of COVID-19 and 3D printed medical devices | Journal of Intellectual Property Law & Practice | Oxford Academic). In essence, OSMS acted as a knowledge commons for hardware: designs and instructions were openly licensed, improved iteratively by peer feedback, and distributed widely to communities in need. Researchers documenting OSMS note that such peer-to-peer production leveraged altruistic motivations and digital connectivity to fill an institutional void ( Socialized leadership and improvisational responding to COVID-19 supply voids - PMC ) ( Socialized leadership and improvisational responding to COVID-19 supply voids - PMC ). The success of OSMS (and similar maker initiatives) in producing millions of units of PPE demonstrated how commons-based production can mobilize quickly, though it also raised questions about safety standards and IP (many designs skirted patent restrictions in the public interest) (Rethinking intellectual property rights and commons-based peer production in times of crisis: The case of COVID-19 and 3D printed medical devices | Journal of Intellectual Property Law & Practice | Oxford Academic) (Rethinking intellectual property rights and commons-based peer production in times of crisis: The case of COVID-19 and 3D printed medical devices | Journal of Intellectual Property Law & Practice | Oxford Academic). OSMS stands as a vivid case of social networks enabling large-scale cooperative knowledge-sharing – in this case, engineering know-how – with life-saving impact.

- The COVID Tracking Project: In the United States, early pandemic response was hampered by inconsistent data reporting from states. A group of volunteers launched the COVID Tracking Project (CTP) in March 2020 to compile accurate, up-to-date statistics on cases, tests, hospitalizations, and more (COVID Tracking Project - Wikipedia) (COVID Tracking Project - Wikipedia). Started by two journalists and a data scientist and later hosted by *The Atlantic*, CTP evolved into a collaborative, volunteer-run open data effort. Dozens of contributors manually gathered data from state health department websites and press releases daily (COVID Tracking Project - Wikipedia), essentially crowdsourcing a reliable national dataset when no federal unified source existed. All data and documentation were published under an open

license for anyone to use (COVID Tracking Project - Wikipedia). Over time the project grew to hundreds of volunteers and even some paid staff, demonstrating a hybrid model of citizen science and professional journalism. The COVID Tracking Project became an authoritative resource used by universities, newsrooms, and policymakers (The COVID Tracking Project Par - Reveal - Apple Podcasts). Its success underscored the power of a knowledge commons approach – volunteers pooling labor to produce a public dataset – especially in a time of urgent need. It also highlighted how *social media and online collaboration tools (like spreadsheets, Slack, GitHub)* can coordinate large-scale data commons initiatives rapidly.

- Open COVID Pledge: Not only grassroots communities, but major corporations also took steps toward the idea of a knowledge commons during COVID-19. In 2020, a coalition of companies and universities launched the *Open COVID Pledge*, urging organizations to make their patents and copyrights freely available for pandemic response. Tech giants including IBM, Microsoft, Facebook, and Amazon signed on, collectively pledging hundreds of thousands of patents for open use (No Take-Backs: Moderna's Attempt to Renege on its Vaccine Patent ...). In effect, this represented a shift from proprietary control to a commons mindset – at least temporarily – to accelerate innovation in treatments, diagnostics, and medical devices. By one estimate, around 500,000 patents were pledged under OCP (with another million under a parallel initiative in Japan) (No Take-Backs: Moderna's Attempt to Renege on its Vaccine Patent ...). While the practical impact of freeing these intellectual properties is hard to measure, the Open COVID Pledge was symbolically important. It signaled recognition that traditional IP regimes can hinder the rapid sharing of knowledge, and that in a crisis, openness and collaboration should override exclusivity (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core) (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). This aligns with long-standing commons arguments that treating knowledge as a public good leads to better societal outcomes – a point driven home by the urgent need for globally accessible vaccines and technologies (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19

for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core).

Each of these examples – Wikipedia, OSMS, the COVID Tracking Project, the Open COVID Pledge, and numerous smaller community efforts – illustrates a facet of how peer knowledge commons expanded or adapted during the pandemic. They range from volunteer crowd-documentation and open-data projects to ad-hoc engineering collaborations and formal open licensing pledges. Common to all is the reliance on peer networks and digital platforms to coordinate action. Through social media posts, wikis, shared documents, and online forums, disparate individuals were able to self-organize and produce shared knowledge resources at scale. These case studies also show the interplay between *bottom-up* initiative and *top-down* support – e.g. the WHO leveraging Wikipedia's volunteer network, or companies supporting open innovation – in strengthening the knowledge commons.

## Platform Governance, Moderation, and Algorithms during COVID-19

The pandemic forced social networking platforms to reckon with their governance models in new ways. On one hand, platforms were crucial enablers of knowledge sharing; on the other, they became vectors for dangerous misinformation. In response, major social media companies implemented significant shifts in content moderation and algorithmic intervention to manage COVID-19 content. This period thus offers a rich look at how platform policies can foster or hinder commons-based peer production of reliable knowledge.

Content Moderation Crackdowns: Early in 2020, as false cures and conspiracy theories proliferated, platforms moved beyond their usual laissez-faire stance and enacted stricter moderation for pandemic-related misinformation. Facebook and Instagram, for example, expanded their policies to remove verifiably false claims about COVID-19 that could harm public health. By mid-2020 Facebook had compiled a list of *about 80 specific false claims* (e.g. "the virus is a hoax," "vaccines cause magnetism") that would be outright removed from the platform (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board). Posts pushing these falsehoods were deleted rather than just flagged. Between March 2020 and July 2022, Meta (Facebook's parent company) reports removing 27 million pieces of COVID-19 misinformation across Facebook and Instagram (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board) – an extraordinary scale of takedown, even accounting for 1.3 million appeals that resulted in restored posts. Twitter likewise stepped up enforcement: it introduced

labels and warning banners on tweets containing disputed or misleading COVID-19 information, and it required removal of tweets that advanced harmful false claims (especially about vaccines) (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). YouTube implemented a policy to ban COVID misinformation videos, resulting in high-profile removals such as the "Plandemic" conspiracy video in May 2020. These measures marked a notable shift from pre-pandemic moderation, drawing firmer lines around veracity in the interest of public safety.

Information Hubs and Prompts: In tandem with removing bad information, platforms tried to elevate reliable information through design interventions. Twitter added a special COVID-19 "tab" in its Explore page and search prompts that directed users to public health authorities when they searched pandemic-related keywords (Coronavirus: Staying safe and informed on Twitter) (Coronavirus: Staying safe and informed on Twitter). It also verified the accounts of prominent health experts to boost their visibility (Coronavirus: Staying safe and informed on Twitter). Facebook placed persistent banners on the top of users' feeds linking to its COVID-19 Information Center, populated with updates from health organizations (Combating Misinformation - Meta). Reddit, as noted, put homepage banners and pinned announcements to guide users toward authoritative sources (Misinformation and COVID-19: What Reddit is Doing : r/ModSupport). These efforts essentially treated the platforms as *information commons* where official knowledge needed a boost to reach users; algorithms were tweaked to prioritize content from sources like the WHO or CDC. For example, YouTube adjusted its recommendation system to show more videos from authoritative channels (news outlets, medical sources) when people searched COVID topics, and added info panels with facts from the WHO on relevant videos (Infodemic - World Health Organization (WHO)). Such algorithmic tuning – privileging accuracy over pure engagement – represented an attempt to *foster a healthier knowledge ecosystem* on platforms historically plagued by clickbait dynamics.

Cross-Platform Collaboration: Another governance shift was unprecedented cooperation between companies (and with governments) to combat misinformation. Reddit's administrators reported *enhanced cooperation with counterparts across the industry* to monitor coordinated disinformation campaigns (Misinformation and COVID-19: What Reddit is Doing : r/ModSupport). This included sharing threat intelligence about bot networks or state-sponsored propaganda related to COVID-19. Tech companies participated in regular calls convened by agencies like the WHO and government task forces to discuss trends in misinformation and align responses (Misinformation and COVID-19: What

Reddit is Doing : r/ModSupport). In essence, the crisis pushed normally siloed competitors to work together in defense of the public's information commons. While such collaboration was largely behind-the-scenes, it indicated a recognition that misinformation is a systemic, cross-platform problem requiring collective action.

Addressing the Algorithmic Dilemma: Despite these efforts, the pandemic also exposed how platform algorithms themselves can hinder commons-based knowledge sharing by amplifying fringe content. Critics pointed out that moderation is often reactive, whereas the underlying *curation algorithms* continued to drive engagement with sensational or false posts. A study by the advocacy group Accountable Tech in mid-2020 found that Facebook's recommendation algorithm was still steering users toward groups peddling COVID-19 conspiracies, such as those promoting false cures or "Plandemic" misinformation, even after policy changes (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech) (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech). This suggests the platform's profit-driven design (maximizing user engagement and ad views) was at odds with its public pledges to stop misinformation. *"Facebook's content curation algorithms have actively promoted the spread of dangerous misinformation,"* the report concluded, noting that the company was effectively fighting against its own system (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech) (Facebook's Algorithms Undermined COVID-19 Response, Spread Misinformation After George Floyd's Killing - Accountable Tech). Similar concerns were raised about YouTube's recommendation engine earlier in the pandemic, although YouTube later claimed improvements in down-ranking borderline content. The tension between open commons and closed algorithms became a focal point of scholarly debate: some argued that true knowledge commons cannot thrive on platforms governed by opaque, attention-maximizing algorithms, unless those algorithms are reformed for transparency and public interest (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board).

Community Moderation and Self-Governance: It's important to note that not all moderation was top-down. On platforms like Reddit and Facebook Groups, *community moderators* (often volunteers) played a crucial role in setting standards and curating content. For example, the moderators of Reddit's r/Coronavirus enforced strict rules on source quality (allowing only news from reputable outlets or

published research) and quickly removed misinformation, effectively creating a highly curated knowledge hub within Reddit ([PDF] A Content Analysis of r/coronavirus during the Early Pandemic). Many of these moderators consulted with experts and coordinated across subreddits to keep information accurate (Facts do not speak for themselves: Community norms, dialog, and ...). This demonstrates how platform governance during the pandemic also included empowering user communities to maintain their own knowledge commons. However, it was not without friction – moderators occasionally criticized platform admins for not doing enough globally, and some misinfo-laden groups on Facebook simply operated outside the reach of capable moderation. The contrast between well-moderated communities (like certain Reddit forums or Wikipedia) and laissez-faire ones (like some open Facebook groups) during COVID-19 underscored the impact governance choices have on the quality of collective knowledge.

By the later stages of the pandemic (2021–2022), platform policies began to adapt to new conditions. With vaccination campaigns and evolving scientific consensus, companies had to update what counted as "misinformation" (e.g. earlier speculative statements sometimes became outdated truths or vice versa). Both Facebook and Twitter sought external guidance on these gray areas. In mid-2022, Meta (Facebook) asked its independent Oversight Board for policy advice on whether to continue removing certain COVID misinformation or take a less restrictive approach as the acute emergency waned (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board). In early 2023, the Oversight Board recommended that Meta maintain removal of the most harmful false claims as long as COVID remained a global health emergency, but also prepare to phase out the emergency measures and increase transparency about its interventions (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board) (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board). Twitter, for its part, announced in March 2021 that it would start dialing back some emergency policies (like its "civic integrity" rules related to election misinformation, and by extension some COVID rules) (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). Eventually, under new ownership in late 2022, Twitter made a sharp governance turn by quietly ending enforcement of its COVID-19 misinformation policy altogether (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). As of November 23, 2022, Twitter stopped policing COVID misinformation, raising concerns that false claims could again surge on the platform (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters) (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). This change was part of a broader shift in Twitter's moderation philosophy under Elon Musk, emphasizing laissez-faire free speech and cutting moderation staff

(Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). The whiplash in Twitter's policy – from being a leader in labeling misinformation to effectively an anything-goes stance – illustrates how platform governance is highly contingent on leadership and business priorities. It also suggests a potential setback for the gains made in nurturing a trustworthy knowledge commons on that platform.

## Post-Pandemic Trends and Ongoing Debates

As the acute phase of the COVID-19 crisis subsided by 2022–2023, the trajectory of peer knowledge commons entered a new chapter, marked by both consolidation of lessons learned and emerging challenges. Many of the open practices and collaborations born out of the pandemic have left a lasting imprint. For instance, the scientific community's embrace of preprints and data sharing is likely here to stay in some form, having demonstrated the efficiency of rapid, open dissemination (How preprints accelerated science communication during the ...). Likewise, institutions are more cognizant of the *importance of open access* to research in public health emergencies, as evidenced by initiatives to create permanent open science platforms and the WHO's considerations for an international treaty on pandemic data sharing. The volunteer networks and relationships forged – whether among Wikipedia editors, open source medical makers, or grassroots data trackers – have strengthened the broader ecosystem of the knowledge commons, potentially ready to be mobilized for future crises or other global challenges (like climate change or monkeypox outbreaks).

Social networking platforms have also incorporated some governance changes into their standard operations. The concept of aggressive misinformation moderation, once unthinkable at scale, is now part of the policy repertoire (even if contested). Facebook, YouTube, and others continue to apply *fact-check labels and remove certain egregious falsehoods* (especially related to health or elections) (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters), a practice expanded during COVID-19. Twitter's experiment with community-driven fact-checking (through its Community Notes/Birdwatch feature launched in 2021) reflects a trend of platforms leveraging *peer production for content moderation* – essentially inviting users to collaboratively add context to potentially misleading posts, a crowdsourced check on information quality. This blurs the line between platform governance and community action, aligning with the commons ethos by empowering users to police misinformation collectively. While results have been mixed, such initiatives carry forward the pandemic

lesson that no single authority can manage the deluge of information alone; instead, networked approaches combining algorithms, expert input, and user contributions are needed.

However, significant debates continue regarding the balance between open knowledge sharing and control of harmful content. The COVID-19 experience sharpened the longstanding tension between free expression and moderation. Some scholars and activists argue that the platforms' COVID policies, though well-intentioned, set worrisome precedents for censorship and centralized control over discourse. They question who defines "misinformation" and warn of overreach that might stifle legitimate discussion or the peer production of knowledge (for example, Facebook initially censored discussion of a "lab leak" theory as misinformation, only to later allow it as the discourse evolved). On the flip side, public health experts and many in the commons community counter that *extraordinary measures to curb demonstrably false information* were justified – even required – to protect the integrity of the knowledge commons and public safety (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board) (Removal of COVID-19 misinformation | Oversight Board). This debate feeds into a broader scholarly discourse on platform power, transparency, and the need for oversight (whether via independent boards, regulations, or user governance) to ensure platforms serve the public interest in knowledge-sharing, not just their private interests.

Another trend is the search for more decentralized or community-owned platforms as alternatives to the big corporate social networks. The instability of Twitter's policies and the dominance of a few tech giants spurred interest in federated social media (e.g. Mastodon) and other models that align with digital commons principles (open-source, community-moderated, non-profit). Advocates suggest that knowledge commons may flourish better in these environments, free from the profit motives and opaque algorithms of Big Tech. While these alternative platforms remain relatively niche post-pandemic, they represent a potential shift in how peer production communities choose to host their interactions – possibly moving toward spaces where governance is more democratic and *commons-oriented*.

In academia and policy circles, the pandemic prompted fresh calls to treat knowledge as a global public good. If anything, COVID-19 exposed how fragmented and proprietary the information landscape had become, and how that hindered effective response (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core) (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a

fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). Lessons learned documents (such as the Cambridge *Global Sustainability* briefing) argue that expanding open-source and commons-based models is *critical not only for pandemics but for tackling sustainability challenges broadly* (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). There is a push to reform incentive structures in science and technology – rewarding data sharing, investing in collaborative platforms, and revisiting intellectual property laws that may impede rapid innovation (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core) (Open knowledge commons versus privatized gain in a fractured information ecology: lessons from COVID-19 for the future of sustainability | Global Sustainability | Cambridge Core). In short, the crisis has reinvigorated the movement for open knowledge and questioned the viability of purely market-driven models in producing socially beneficial outcomes. Yet, reconciling this with existing economic and political systems remains an ongoing struggle.

## Conclusion

The period during and after the COVID-19 pandemic has been a litmus test for peer knowledge commons in the age of social networks. On one hand, it showcased the immense potential of collaborative knowledge production: scientists sharing data in real time, volunteers building global information resources, and online communities organizing to solve problems from misinformation to PPE design. Digital platforms, despite their flaws, served as the connective tissue that allowed these peer networks to form and function at scale. The pandemic turbocharged open science and proved that rapid, open collaboration can save lives and advance knowledge faster than traditional models (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO) (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO). It also demonstrated the resilience of projects like Wikipedia and open data repositories under pressure, as well as the willingness of people and organizations to embrace openness (witness the surge in open-access research and patent pledges) (Open science: A global movement catches on | UNESCO) (No Take-Backs: Moderna's Attempt to Renege on its Vaccine Patent ...). These developments have cemented the notion that knowledge commons are not just utopian ideals, but practical necessities in times of crisis.

On the other hand, the era also illuminated the challenges and fragility of knowledge commons within profit-driven social media ecosystems. The unchecked spread of false information taught us that simply having an open platform is not enough – governance matters immensely. Platforms had to intervene with stronger moderation and algorithm tweaks to preserve a baseline of truth, essentially acting as stewards (or gatekeepers) of the commons. This raises complex questions about who oversees our digital knowledge spaces and under what guidelines. The oscillation of platform policies – from tightening during the emergency to loosening afterward – suggests that the governance of online knowledge is still in flux, often reactive and influenced by corporate or political shifts (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters) (Twitter rolls back COVID misinformation policy | Reuters). Ensuring that the *public interest* in accurate knowledge is protected on social networks remains a pressing issue.

In sum, the COVID-19 pandemic catalyzed an evolution in knowledge-sharing practices, with digital commons and peer production rising to prominence in both admirable and troubled ways. It brought to the forefront key trends such as the integration of community-driven content moderation, the mainstreaming of open-access science, and the acknowledgement that *information integrity is a collective responsibility* (Key Quotes: Combating the Infodemic Surrounding COVID-19 | ICFJ). The experiences of this period have enriched scholarly debates on topics ranging from platform regulation to the sociology of collaborative communities. They underscore that while technology provides the tools for global knowledge commons, it is human coordination, governance, and trust that ultimately determine the outcomes. As we move forward, the lessons learned during COVID-19 will inform how we cultivate robust, inclusive, and resilient knowledge commons – whether on today's dominant platforms or the alternative digital commons of tomorrow. The stakes are high: our capacity to confront future crises and complex societal challenges may well depend on the strength of the peer knowledge commons we build now.

Sources:

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